RMIT UNIVERSITY School of English & University Pathways

Helping students follow lectures and extended explanations

Practical guidance for subject lecturers - D03-S1–S6

Students listening in English need to follow the language, understand the subject ideas and recognise how those ideas connect. They may also be interpreting slides and taking notes. Make the organisation visible and give students opportunities to process and check the explanation.

1. Preview and signpost the structure

Begin with the main question and a short outline. During the explanation, tell students when you move to another point. Briefly summarise what you have covered before continuing.

2. Break explanations into sections and check understanding

Pause after a meaningful section. Give students a focused question or a short paired explanation task. Use their responses to decide whether to clarify or continue.

3. Support speech with key points and visuals

Choose a short outline, diagram or worked example that helps explain the content. In this toolkit, we recommend keeping slide text selective rather than displaying a transcript.

4. Make connections explicit

State whether ideas show cause, contrast or sequence. Where *this* or *it* could be ambiguous, name the concept. For example: “This increase in demand…” rather than “This…”

5. Guide students through visuals

Explain what students should look at, what the labels represent and how the visual supports your point.

6. Mark asides and return clearly

Finish the main idea before adding background or an anecdote. Signal the departure, then tell students when you return to the main explanation.

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Worked example: explaining declining profit

The following fictional business example shows how to combine the six strategies.

Stage	What the lecturer displays or says
Preview	Display: Profit: revenue and costs. Say: "Why can profit fall when sales increase? We'll first examine revenue, then costs, and finally compare them."
Explain with selective support	Display: Profit = revenue − costs. Say: "Revenue is the income from sales. Profit is what remains after costs are deducted."
Pause and check	"Take a moment to think: if revenue increases, must profit increase? Explain your answer to a partner." Invite a response and clarify before continuing.
Connect the ideas	"Higher revenue can increase profit. However, profit may fall if costs increase by a larger amount."
Guide through evidence	Display the table below. Say: "Compare the revenue figures first. Revenue increased by VND 20 million. Now compare costs: they increased by VND 30 million. The larger increase in costs explains the fall in profit."
Mark an aside and return	"A brief background point: this company recently introduced delivery. Returning to the figures, delivery might help explain the cost increase, but we would need more evidence to confirm that."
Close and check application	"The key point is that higher revenue does not guarantee higher profit. Write one sentence explaining what happened in this case."

Fictional figures displayed during the explanation

VND million	Month 1	Month 2
Revenue	100	120
Costs	70	100
Profit	30	20

Check that students explain the relationship between the figures, rather than simply state that profit fell. If responses are unclear, return to the equation and work through the comparison.

Before your next lesson:

- Identify the main question and the sequence of ideas.
- Prepare phrases for transitions and important connections.
- Choose a useful visual and plan how you will explain it.
- Decide where students will pause and what they will do.
- Prepare one question that requires them to apply the explanation.

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Supporting guidance

TAEC Erasmus+ project (2017–2020), *EMI Handbook*, sections 2.2–2.3, supports structuring, explicit connections, visual explanations and signalling asides.

University of Minnesota, *Supporting and Engaging Multilingual Students by Making Content and Lectures More Accessible*, supports processing pauses and multiple modes of presentation.

The worked example, planning checklist and advice on selective slide text were developed for this toolkit. This draft requires contextual review.